Indo–Pacific Antecedents: India and Asia, c. 100–1300 CE

While many documented interactions in early India were with the north and west, significant Indian engagements were underway to India's east and south, both across the Himalayas by land and south by sea to Southeast Asia. One aberration, in that it involved military engagement, concerns the Chola Empire, ancient India's most significant maritime power, sometimes described as a thalassocracy (seaborne empire). A family claiming the old Chola name and its heroic associations rose to power in present-day Tamil Nadu in the ninth century and established prominence over significant parts of southern India. They sent military expeditions and raiding parties by land as far as Bengal, as well as by sea. Chola inscriptions describe raids over locations identified as the Kra Isthmus, Malay peninsula, and Sumatra. Anuradhapura in today's Sri Lanka was attacked and the northern part of the island was ruled directly for a while by the Cholas. (They were not the first Indian rulers to militarily venture into Sri Lanka. In the ninth century, Pandya King Srimara Srivallabha invaded the island and took a golden Buddha image back to his capital Madurai.) [20] More famously, although for reasons that can only be surmised, a Chola armada during the reign of Rajendra Chola sailed to Srivijaya in Southeast Asia and sacked several cities in Sumatra and the Malay Peninsula. [21]

The Indian cultural footprint in Southeast Asia was certainly wider than the area of direct Chola military intervention. Tamil, which was the Chola courtly language along with Sanskrit, appears in inscriptions in Burma, Thailand, Sumatra, and southern China. Kingdoms in Burma and Cambodia sent ambassadors to the Chola court, and a Buddhist *vihara* (monastery) was established by the king of Srivijaya in Nagapattinam. [22] This period in India also includes among the earliest references to navigation charts, such as in the fifth century *Brihat-katha-shloka-samgraha*, an abridged retelling by Budhaswami of an epic adventure story. Given the breadth and frequency of contacts between India and Southeast Asia, it can be presumed that such charts—of which none survive today—were commonly used. [23]